Diego Javier Piña Lopez, LMSW, MPA

GOVERNMENT SERVICE DELIVERY | HUMAN-CENTERED SYSTEMS | PROGRAM PORTFOLIOS & PARTNERSHIPS

Tucson, Arizona | (520) 470-7387 | diegojplopez@gmail.com

EXECUTIVE PROFILE

Government and nonprofit program leader with more than a decade of experience delivering complex, multi-stakeholder services at the intersection of public systems, community organizations, policy, and technology-enabled operations. Former Executive Director of Casa Alitas, where I led a $12M humanitarian reception portfolio across multiple sites, serving up to 1,800 people nightly and leading 60+ staff and 600+ volunteers. I build trusted government and community partnerships, translate frontline insight into operational and data-system improvements, develop teams, manage grants and budgets, and communicate clearly across political, institutional, and cultural differences.

CORE LEADERSHIP AREAS

- Government Service Delivery & Partner Management
- Portfolio Strategy, Delivery & Risk Management
- People Leadership, Coaching & Team Development
- Human-Centered, Technology-Enabled Operations
- Safety Net–Adjacent Access & Referral Systems
- Policy, Program Evaluation & Systems Change
- Federal, State, County & Community Partnerships
- Data Systems, Dashboards & Outcome Reporting
- Grants, Funders & Public Accountability
- Cross-Functional Delivery & Change Leadership

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Researcher & Content Expert - Cherokee Federal | Remote | Apr 2023 - Aug 2025

- Produced daily operational reports and decision-ready dashboards for New York government officials, translating fast-moving shelter capacity and service-delivery conditions into clear action, risk, and resource signals.
- Assessed medical services for displaced refugees nationwide as part of an evaluation of Afghan refugee resettlement and consulted with shelters on referral and long-term settlement systems.
- Developed comparative dashboards to help government and community partners assess resettlement capacity, identify service gaps, and plan for migration surges across U.S. locations.
- Managed a team of 10 case managers, setting priorities and supporting partner engagement, employment placement, and follow-up across Arizona.

Executive Director, Migrant Services (Casa Alitas) - Catholic Community Services | Tucson, AZ | Jun 2019 - May 2024

- Progressed from volunteer service beginning in 2014 to Program Coordinator, Director, and ultimately Executive Director, carrying forward a strong understanding of both frontline practice and executive operations.
- Directed a $12M multi-site humanitarian service portfolio serving up to 1,800 asylum seekers nightly; led 62 staff and more than 600 volunteers while aligning operational delivery with government, funder, and community commitments.
- Led a trauma-informed reception environment for individuals and families arriving directly after release from DHS custody, intentionally treating the shelter as a bridge from custody toward community life, autonomy, family connection, and independent travel.
- Helped adapt and operationalize Psychological First Aid and trauma-informed practices through staff and volunteer training, communication, service flow, leadership expectations, and the physical and organizational environment.

• Built and sustained a regional response network with county and federal agencies, NGOs, faith organizations, and community partners; secured more than $13M in public grants and philanthropic funding and translated funder requirements into accountable delivery.

• Developed real-time operational and demographic data systems to guide decisions and served as a public spokesperson explaining migration policy, humanitarian conditions, and organizational response.

Consultant - Catholic Charities USA | Alexandria, VA | Remote | Sep 2022 - Jun 2024

• Designed iterative data systems and referral mechanisms that improved coordination between border asylum services and 10 interior cities receiving case-management referrals.

• Implemented program metrics to track interactions and outcomes across partner organizations and support more consistent referral practices.

Senior Border Specialist - Save the Children | Remote / U.S.-Mexico Border | Jul 2021 - Oct 2022

• Managed U.S. border response programs and partnerships with humanitarian organizations and contributed to planning and allocation of a $7M response portfolio.

• Implemented monitoring systems, monthly partner check-ins, and cross-border coordination calls to evaluate program effectiveness and surface operational challenges.

EDUCATION, TRAINING & LEADERSHIP DEVELOPMENT

Master of Social Work (MSW) - Arizona State University, 2019

Master of Public Administration (MPA) - Arizona State University, 2018

Bachelor of Arts - Theater Education - University of Arizona, 2013

Bachelor of Arts - Religious Studies - University of Arizona, 2013

• UNICEF Psychological First Aid - Train-the-Trainer Certification (2021)

• Arizona Community Foundation - Board Leadership Training Program (completed 2026)

• Arizona Community Foundation - Executive Leadership / CEO Development Program (currently enrolled)

BOARD LEADERSHIP & SELECTED RECOGNITION

• Center for Victims of Torture - Board Member (2023 - Present); Policy & Advisory Committee and CEO search committee participant.

• Kaleidoscope Humanitarian Aid - Founding Board Member & Secretary (2025 - Present); helped establish governance framework, bylaws, and board procedures.

• Community Partner Award - National Association of Social Workers, Arizona Chapter (2022); Emerging Leader / Emerging Social Worker of the Year (2019).

PUBLIC COMMUNICATION

Regularly represented humanitarian operations and migration realities in public-facing settings, including interviews or coverage with CNN, Reuters, NPR, and The New York Times. Experienced explaining complex, emotionally charged issues in clear language for government, community, media, and public audiences.